

Negotiating Gender Role Expectations: Rhetorical Leadership and Women in the US Senate

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Abstract *The historical paucity of US women senators has provided little opportunity to study women at one of the highest and most prestigious leadership levels. Through a content analysis of 12 months of public discourse in a variety of media, we explore the rhetorical leadership of women senators as they carry out their elected roles. Results indicate that women senators use significantly less aggressive and more ambivalent speech when compared to political norms, and are less likely to use terms denoting accomplishment, praise and human interest. Overall, our results suggest that women continue to feel the effects of gender stereotypes and expectations in higher levels of political office, and these effects may have important negative implications for perceptions of their leadership and effectiveness.*

Keywords *gender; leadership; political; rhetoric*

Introduction

You never mentioned being a woman . . . you hoped no one noticed. (US Senator Barbara Boxer)

There cannot be true democracy unless women's voices are heard. (US Senator Hillary Rodham Clinton)

The interaction of gender and leadership issues is of critical importance as women advance into managerial and political roles at the local, state, national, and international levels. Despite the fact that women are moving into such highly visible positions as presidents, prime ministers, and CEOs, they remain a distinct minority. As a result, women's behaviors as high-ranking leaders have come under added scrutiny, in part because they have historically rarely filled such positions. As more women are running for political office and being promoted into top managerial roles, relatively few empirical studies have examined women's rhetorical leadership in such high-ranking, powerful positions.

Scholars have examined a variety of potential reasons for the comparative lack of women in higher positions of power (see Kahn, 1992; Kahn & Goldenberg, 1991; Kelly, 1983; Rhode, 2003). In particular, the role of gender stereotypes, and their subsequent effect on voting behavior, has been examined in detail. According to Huddy and Terkildsen (1993a), differing expectations among voters about the types of issues handled well by male and female politicians have proven to be the most consistent form of political gender stereotyping (see also Leeper, 1991; Sapiro, 1981, 1983). In addition, voters are likely to ascribe different traits, competencies, behaviors, and political beliefs to male and female politicians (Koch, 2000). However, it is unclear whether these attributions are accurate depictions of women's political leadership behaviors once elected. The current study focuses on one important aspect of women's leadership in office: the rhetorical leadership styles of female US senators.

In the United States Senate, women's representation has improved markedly since the 'Year of the Woman' precipitated by the 1992 election. This election tripled the ranks of female senators from two to six of 100 total senators (two senators are allotted for each of the 50 US States), and increased female representation in the House of Representatives from 28 (6%) to 48 (11%) of 435 total (the number of Representatives per US state is based on its population). While the total number of women senators and representatives still remained markedly low, the election marked the first time in American history that a single US state (California) was represented in the Senate by two women. A week after the election, a popular *Washington Post* photograph was published representing the female senators; never before had four women been elected to the Senate in a single election year. In addition, the so-called 'Year of the Woman' spurred a flurry of research into women as candidates, differential press coverage of men versus women in political campaigns, gender stereotypes in voters' assessments of male versus female candidates, and gender differences in the exercise of leadership.

Despite existing research on gender stereotypes (for overviews, see Rhode, 2003 and Valian, 1999), women's differential use of power and influence (e.g. Cantor & Bernay, 1992; Kathlene, 1994), and explorations of their effectiveness (e.g. Jeydel & Taylor, 2003; Thomas, 1994) relatively little work has been done concerning how women's current minority status affects their actual leadership communications once in office. The current article focuses on women senators for several reasons. Throughout most of the US Senate's history, the Senate was almost entirely male. Perhaps in keeping with the notion of the Senate as a more 'elite' body than the House of Representatives, few women ran for the Senate and even fewer were elected. Historically, the first woman in the Senate was Rebecca Latimer Felton, who served for a single day in 1922. No women served between 1922 to 1931, 1945 to 1947, and 1973 to 1978. Only since 1978 has there been at least one woman in the Senate, and there were still few women in the Senate far into the 20th century, long after women began to make up a significant portion of the membership of the US House of Representatives. The 1992 election, however, diminished the popular perception of the Senate as an exclusive 'boys' club', and more women in both the Democratic and Republican parties began to run for the Senate in subsequent years. However, nearly 10 years after the 'Year of the Woman', the US remained 50th worldwide in the percentage of women elected to legislative office (Mandel, 2001).

By 2007, women comprised a paltry but steadily growing 16 per cent of the total US Senate.

Given the historical paucity of women in the US Senate and its status as a powerful, prestigious and traditionally male-dominated body, women senators are likely keenly aware of gender stereotypes that have been established in previous research. However, it remains unclear to what extent, if any, these stereotypes hold true for women as they perform their duties as elected officials. Previous research has primarily focused on women as candidates, their use of power and influence, and the consequences of gender stereotypes on issue selection and voting behaviors and committee assignments. Relatively fewer studies have looked at women's leadership communications once in office, in order to examine whether or not the stereotypes made salient through the election process influence their rhetorical leadership in the role of US senator.

The purpose of this study is to examine whether or not women senators' rhetorical leadership as elected officials reinforces or contradicts popular stereotypes about women politicians. The interrelationship between leadership and communication has a long history in both areas of scholarship. Thayer (1988) argues that leadership and communication are inseparable, while Fairhurst and Sarr (1996) define leadership as meaning creation through discourse. Conger (1991) suggests that *how* leaders craft and frame their messages through language is a vital component of leadership that has true impact. Through an examination of women senators' rhetoric over a 12-month period in office, we examine the content of their leader communications in light of stereotypes of women leaders. While some previous research suggests that women conceptualize issues differently, define problems differently, and speak of political issues differently than their male colleagues (Kathlene, 1989, 1994), much remains unknown concerning women senators' leadership and communication styles once in political office. Based on previous work concerning trait and gender stereotypes, we develop and test several hypotheses about the rhetorical content of female senators' language as they carry out their elected positions.

Gender stereotypes in leadership

Theoretical work on gender differences in leadership suggests that manifested differences may vary by occupation or social realm, according to the extent of what Eagly and Johnson (1990) have termed 'gender congeniality'. Eagly et al. (1995: 129) define gender congeniality as 'the fit between gender roles and particular leadership roles'. In realms such as the military (see Boyce & Herd, 2003), leadership positions are more linked to stereotypically masculine characteristics, and are therefore more congenial to men. Similarly, in realms such as education and nursing, leadership is defined in more stereotypically feminine ways and considered more congenial to women. For example, Schein's (1973, 2001) on-going work suggests that people's beliefs about managers are more similar to their beliefs about men than women, suggesting that managerial roles are often gender congenial for men (see also Sczesny, 2003). Research on gender and occupational stereotypes suggests that political office is perceived as a predominantly masculine occupation, suggesting that the position of US senator is gender congenial for men as well (see Hedlund et al., 1979; White et al., 1989). Following this reasoning, the legislature, as an institution

created by men and historically dominated by men, may reward and advance individuals who possess quintessentially 'male' qualities such as competitiveness and individualism (Jeydel & Taylor, 2003). These qualities may not be conducive to the style of leadership women have brought to the legislatures, which is more integrative, collaborative, and consensual (Carroll, 2001; Kathlene, 1994; Rosenthal, 1998; Thomas, 1994). In contrast to a traditional view of the legislature as the 'classic seat of transactional leadership' (Burns, cited in Rosenthal, 1998), a kind of competitive bargaining procedure to broker particular interests, women's legislative leadership has been argued to involve more shared values and creative consensus.

According to Eagly et al. (2000), gender roles have a dual influence on manifest leadership behaviors, in that: 1) people react to leaders in terms of gendered expectancies that encourage leaders to respond in ways congruent with those expectations; and 2) many people have internalized their gender role to some extent, which leads to differing expectations for one's own behavior in leadership roles (Eagley et al., 2003; Lewis, 1998). The result of these dual expectations is that discretionary aspects of leaders' behaviors may be affected in gender-stereotypical ways.

According to leadership categorization theory (Lord & Maher, 1991) and social role theory (Eagly, 1987), biases toward women in leadership positions stem from discrepancies between stereotypes about women and prototypical leadership behaviors. Forsyth et al.'s (1997) study of appraisals of women leaders affirms both categorization and social-role theory, suggesting that 'perceptual repercussions are likely' (p. 102) if leaders act in ways that are inconsistent with leadership prototypes or sex-role stereotypes. In the political realm, there is substantial evidence to suggest that women in political roles have traditionally dealt with stereotypical evaluations based on their gender (Alexander & Andersen, 1993; Deber, 1982; Sigelman et al., 1987). Eagly et al. (1992) found that women in leadership positions were devalued relative to men when leadership was carried out in stereotypically masculine styles, particularly when that style was autocratic or directive. Perhaps even more relevant to the current study, the devaluation of women leaders was greater when leaders occupied male-dominated roles. Considering the overwhelming majority of men in the US Senate, these findings could have serious negative consequences for how women senators' leadership skills are evaluated.

Gender stereotypes and women politicians

Although there has been a great deal of research on gender stereotypes in managerial positions, less research has been conducted on the effect of gender stereotypes on female politicians and perceptions of their leadership. Glick et al.'s (1995) study of occupational stereotypes found that occupational images are primarily structured on two dimensions: prestige and gender type. Although politicians were not included in the study, the results suggest that more prestigious jobs are frequently associated with male personality traits and analytic skills. In addition, the authors suggest that female candidates for jobs traditionally associated with men are likely to provide counter-stereotypic information about themselves to combat employer biases. To the extent that women senators are aware of gender stereotypes as they move into this traditionally male realm, they may be likely to provide individuating information that is diagnostic of masculine personality traits (Glick, 1991). Supporting this assertion,

women candidates have been argued to go out of their way, particularly when running for higher offices, to portray themselves as nonconformists to traditional gender stereotypes (Huddy & Terkildsen, 1993a).

Research into the masculinity/femininity of local, state, and national political offices suggests that all levels of political office are rated as more stereotypically masculine than feminine (Rosenwasser & Dean, 1989). In addition, masculine characteristics and tasks were rated as being more important to political office, suggesting 'it may behoove women to develop attributes traditionally considered "masculine"' (p. 83). Huddy and Terkildsen (1993b) similarly found a preference for stereotypically male characteristics for higher levels of political office. In addition, some research suggests that women who have been political leaders in the past have exhibited higher masculine characteristics, such as self-confidence, dominance, and achievement (Constantini & Craik, 1972).

For example, candidates such as Geraldine Ferraro, Dianne Feinstein, Ann Richards, and Hillary Rodham Clinton have emphasized their tough, combative, and independent nature in campaigning, leading to the argument that 'women candidates may succeed at the polls because they manage to convince voters that, unlike women in general, they possess desirable masculine political strengths' (Huddy & Terkildsen, 1993b: 504). Kahn's (1993) study of political advertisements in US Senate campaigns found that women candidates frequently stressed leadership and competence issues, perhaps as a way of challenging voters' perceptions of the stereotypical female candidate. In addition, Dolan and Ford (1997: 147) report that contemporary women lawmakers have expanded their areas of activity, simultaneously 'maintaining a concern for their gender while increasing their attention to "nontraditional" areas'. These stereotype-disconfirming behaviors can act to enhance a woman's perceived suitability for non-traditional jobs such as US senator. More research is necessary, however, to determine if women senators continue to emphasize traditionally masculine leadership behaviors *after* the election as they move into the highest leadership positions in increasing numbers.

Boles and Durio's (1980, 1981) work on perceptions of male and female candidates suggests that women candidates may have to present themselves as *both* 'male' and 'female' to satisfy voters' expectations. Similarly, Alexander and Andersen (1993) suggest that successful women candidates feel a double bind of having to be both masculine and feminine. In other words, women are

... welcomed into the political fray, as long as they bring with them their traditional skills, capabilities, and vestiges of their roles as mothers and spouses
... at the same time they have to demonstrate their power, toughness, and capacity to win, traits assumed by most voters to be inherent in most male candidates. (p. 542)

Niven and Zilber's (2001) study of congressional website communications provides evidence for a similar pattern. Their results suggest that congresswomen portray themselves as having diverse interests and 'participating zealously' in the Washington power struggle, yet also place a higher priority on compassion and women's issues. Finally, Thomas' (1997) interviews with over 50 state legislators concludes that women in political office face the need for 'alternative role development' that neither replicates the male model nor relies on traditional female roles.

Taken together, this research suggests that, once elected, women senators may face markedly conflicting expectations in their roles as national leaders.

Leadership stereotypes: balancing ‘masculinity’ and ‘femininity’

Another stream of research has explored the consequences of differing leadership styles for women’s effectiveness and likeability. Watson (1988) found that women are inclined to reverse roles in leadership positions, behaving more dominantly in leadership situations particularly when dealing with men. Further, she argues that this type of role reversal may actually undermine women’s effectiveness as leaders. Her results indicate that women who enact a stereotypically masculine approach are less influential and less positively received than women who take a more considerate, problem-solving approach, particularly when dealing with male subordinates.

Johnson’s (1976) early work on gender roles and the use of power and influence is also relevant here. She argues that women and men use power differently, and there are negative consequences of this differential usage: it is acceptable and even expected that men will use stronger, more aggressive sources of power, while women are limited to the use of more indirect sources of power (see also Cantor & Bernay, 1992). More recent research suggests that women’s differential orientation toward political power means that as committee leaders, women are more likely to place an emphasis on reaching consensus as a way to accomplish their political goals (Kathlene, 1994; Rosenthal, 1997, 1998) and bring citizens into the political process (Dodson & Carroll, 1991). As Rosenthal (1998) states, female committee chairs

adopt leadership strategies closer to an integrative style: sharing power and empowering others, being noncompetitive and inclusion, seeking consensus and mutuality in relationships, and inviting participation rather than imposing dominance. (p. 5)

Following the gender authority hypothesis, Rudman and Kilianski (2000) argue that male dominance in powerful social roles such as politics, law, and the military has produced an implicit male leader prototype, and an association between men and authority that is much stronger than the association between women and authority. Their findings suggest that negative reactions to women in authority positions may stem from an implicit prototype for male leaders and the belief that it is more natural for men to take control. As a result, ‘powerful women may be disliked for breaching an expectancy that men are natural leaders’ (Rudman & Kilianski, 2000: 1316). In the context of the current study, it is important to point out that

all institutions have a distinctively gendered culture, and so too do legislatures . . . ‘gendered institutions’ means that gender is present in the processes, practices, images and ideologies, and distributions of power. (Acker, cited in Rosenthal, 1998: 5)

Legislative leadership, as other forms of leadership, is situated conduct that is not gender neutral. In the US legislature, the historical predominance of male leadership has led to a prototype of legislative leadership in which stereotypically male behavior ‘has been conflated as institutional behavior’ (Rosenthal, 1998: 7). Thomas (1994) similarly points out:

Many participants and observers of legislative life decry its perpetuation of values that reward individual achievement above collective benefit. Because women have traditionally been associated with nurturant, less individualistic values, some people assume that they will transform the political arena along 'kinder, gentler' lines . . . bringing women into politics in far greater numbers is the key to rescuing politics from a rampant individualism that results in deadlock or inadequate policy-making. (pp. 12–13)

Whether implicit or institutionalized, the more masculine leader prototype for the US Senate may also make it more difficult for women to be perceived as both likable and competent as legislative leaders. Importantly, even individuals who possess consciously egalitarian beliefs are susceptible to implicitly negative attitudes toward women in authority (see Spence & Helmreich, 1972; Tojahn & Willemsen, 1994). In a recent example, the debate over US Senator Hillary Rodham Clinton's campaign for the presidency illustrates the double bind women politicians face:

It's not that voters and her opponents think Clinton is experienced and competent, and they don't like or trust her. It's that they think she's experienced and competent and that's why they don't like or trust her. (Gerber, 2007: 1)

Other research on women in leadership and managerial roles has examined the consequences of self-promotion for women. Specifically, because social influence is a function of both perceptions of competence as well as social attraction, women may suffer from a backlash effect in which self-promotion may enhance perceptions of their competence and qualifications, but increase their risk of social rejection (Rudman, 1998). Rudman's results suggest 'women pay a price for counter-stereotypical behavior, even though it may be required for a successful career' (1998: 642). However, Rudman also points out that low-status individuals are more likely than higher-status individuals to conform to perceivers' expectations, and McDonald et al. (2004) suggest that higher status may help prevent women from developing negative tokenism expectations in male-dominated work groups. It therefore remains an empirical question whether the costs of stereotype disconfirmation outweigh the benefits for women in the high-status position of senator.

Taken together, previous research suggests a very conflicted set of pressures on women senators. On one hand, they may be encouraged to behave in counter-stereotypical ways that emphasize their suitability and competence in an office that is more gender congenial to men and stereotypically male characteristics. On the other hand, some prior research suggests that women leaders are more likely to behave in more collaborative, interpersonally oriented ways than their male counterparts. Finally, research on self-promotion and the use of power suggests that women may suffer in the realm of likeability to the extent that they engage in these more traditionally male behaviors. This evidence suggests that women senators may actively highlight and hinder relevant information in order to emphasize their stereotypical strengths and overcome their stereotypical weaknesses. Thus, the rhetorical style of women senators may reflect these multiple, conflicting pressures, in that their rhetorical style may be strongly indicative of a traditionally masculine leadership style, while continuing to incorporate elements of a stereotypically feminine approach.

Overall, this line of theory and research seems to suggest that women in powerful roles must exercise power with caution, as negative ramifications are likely if they aggressively assert their power and influence. In the role of senator, however, women are expected to engage in tactics of power and influence. This may lead to an effort to balance power plays with conciliatory, people-focused, consensus-building language, in an effort to mitigate any negative effects of engaging in power-brokering behavior. Thus, we anticipate that women senators will minimize the negative aspects of stereotypically male leadership behaviors such as aggression, focusing instead on their competence and accomplishments. Finally, we hypothesize that women will engage in higher levels of language geared toward enhancing their likeability as leaders, focusing on positive affirmations of the American public as well as more people-focused language.

Hypothesis 1: Women senators will engage in lower levels of active, aggressive speech and higher levels of passive, ambivalent speech when compared to overall norms for politicians.

Hypothesis 2: Women senators will engage in higher levels of speech focused on self-reference and accomplishments as leaders when compared to overall norms for politicians.

Hypothesis 3: To combat the negative effects of challenging gender stereotypes, women senators will focus more on praising the American public, human interest, and positive rhetoric when compared to overall norms for politicians.

Method

To examine our hypotheses, we collected a sample of publicly available comments and speeches from the 13 women US senators in office in 2002. The list of senators, the year they were elected to the Senate, and their party affiliations are listed in Table 1. Using the Guided News Search option in *Lexus-Nexis*, we searched separately for each senator's name in all news transcripts for the 12-month time period from January 2002 until December 2002. (In the case of Jean Carnahan, the searches were ended on Election Day, when she was defeated and her special appointment to the Senate was effectively complete.) These transcripts encompass television broadcasts from all of the major public and cable networks, speeches, press briefings, news conferences and congressional hearing transcripts. Relevant passages from the database search were copied into a text file, and the file was subsequently cleaned to remove all comments from individuals other than the senators. Thus, this sample is representative of the variety of duties a senator performs in office, including media appearances, formal statements, as well as Senate hearings and committees, in a range of different media outlets.

Content analysis

We chose Diction, a computerized content analysis program specifically designed for political discourse, to analyze our data. Diction automatically divides each speech into 500 word passages for ease of comparison with previously established norms

Table 1 *United States senators included in sample*

State	Year elected	Senator	Party
MD	1986	Barbara Mikulski	Democrat
CA	1992	Dianne Feinstein	Democrat
CA	1992	Barbara Boxer	Democrat
WA	1992	Patty Murray	Democrat
TX	1992	Kay Bailey Hutchison	Republican
ME	1994	Olympia Jean Snowe	Republican
LA	1996	Mary Landreiu	Democrat
ME	1996	Susan Collins	Republican
AR	1998	Blanche Lincoln	Democrat
NY	2000	Hilary Rodham Clinton	Democrat
MI	2000	Deborah Stabenow	Democrat
WA	2000	Maria E. Cantwell	Democrat
MO	2000*	Jean Carnahan	Democrat

*Special appointment, term ended 11/02.

(Hart, 2001). Because we wanted the measure of the senators' comments and speeches to be as objective as possible, computerized content analysis was a natural choice. The methodological and philosophical differences between computerized content analysis and human coders have been discussed elsewhere (see Bligh et al., 2004b). Computerized content analysis was particularly appropriate for our analysis due to its ability to uncover aspects of language that even trained human coders may not perceive, independent of political issue or party affiliation.

Diction was specifically designed for political discourse, making it particularly appropriate for the analysis of the leadership rhetoric of the current 13 female senators. For comparative purposes, Diction includes normative statistical data generated from a broad sampling of texts produced primarily in the US between 1945 and 1998. The program outputs a range representing scores of +1/−1 standard deviations from the mean for each of the dictionary variables. Each 500-word segment of the combined texts is computed separately, up to a maximum of 5000 words. In order to examine a potential range of each senator's rhetoric without artificially increasing sample size, we included a random sample of 10 500-word segments for each of the 13 senators. In the case of Blanche Lincoln, we were unable to obtain a full 5000-word sample through the *Lexis-Nexus* searches. Therefore, we have four 500-word segments for Lincoln, bringing the total sample to 124 500-word segments. The dictionaries we examined, along with a brief description and sample words from each, are listed in Table 2.

To examine our hypotheses, we compared the rhetoric of the 13 senators in our sample to normative values encompassing a variety of political activities, including political advertising, political speeches, and public policy speeches (Hart, 2001). These comparative norms allow us to examine our data in relation to a wide range of political rhetoric over a prolonged time period. The political norm thus represents an all-male composite average of previously analyzed speeches and texts in the realms of political advertising, campaign speeches, and public policy speeches.

The norms for political advertising ($n = 553$) include campaign spots presented on television during the presidential campaigns of 1960 and 1976–1996. Republican,

Table 2 *Overview of Diction constructs*

Construct	Description	Sample words
Self-reference	All first person references that reflect the locus of action residing in the speaker and not in the world at large.	I, I'd, I'll, I'm, I've, me, mine, my, myself.
Aggression	Words denoting human competition and forceful action, including physical energy, social domination, and goal-directedness.	Blast, crash, explode, collide, conquest, attacking, violation, commanded, challenging, overcome, mastered, pound, shove, dismantle, overturn, prevent, reduce, defend.
Accomplishment	Words expressing task-completion and organized human behavior.	Establish, finish, influence, proceed, motivated, influence, leader, manage, strengthen, succeed, agenda, enacted, working, leadership.
Ambivalence	Words expressing hesitation or uncertainty, implying a speaker's inability or unwillingness to commit to what is being said.	Allegedly, perhaps, might, almost, approximate, vague, somewhere, baffled, puzzling, hesitate, could, would, dilemma, guess, suppose, seems.
Human interest	Words that concentrate on people and their activities.	He, his, ourselves, them, cousin, wife, grandchild, uncle, friend, baby, human, persons.
Praise	Affirmations of a person, group, or abstract entity.	Dear, delightful, witty, mighty, handsome, beautiful, shrewd, bright, vigilant, reasonable, successful, conscientious, renowned, faithful, good, noble.
Satisfaction	Terms associated with positive affective states, moments of undiminished joy and pleasurable diversion, and moments of triumph. Also included are words of nurturance.	Cheerful, passionate, happiness, thanks, smile, welcome, excited, fun, lucky, celebrating, pride, auspicious, healing, encourage, secure, relieved.

Democratic, and third-party ads are represented in proportion to their prevalence in political campaigns, and promotional, counter-attack and negative ads are equally represented in the sample (see Hart, 2001).

The campaign speeches comparative data set ($n = 2357$) consists of speeches delivered by Democratic, Republican, and third-party presidential candidates between 1948 and 1996. Major party candidates are represented equally in the sample and third-party candidates were represented proportional to the vote. Stump speeches delivered in local and regional settings are included, as well as nationally broadcast campaign addresses.

Public policy speeches ($n = 615$) allows comparison of our sample of women senators to a broad collection of speeches delivered by sitting presidents from Harry

Truman through to Bill Clinton. Included are nationally televised addresses on major policy issues, as well as ceremonial addresses, remarks made during awards ceremonies, and radio briefings. Topics include the Korean Conflict, open-housing and job discrimination, the Soviet Union, national economic policy, Vietnam, and Watergate (Hart, 2001). Overall, the normative data represents a sample of 3525 political texts against which to compare the rhetoric of women senators.

Results

The overall means, standard deviations, and intercorrelations for each of the constructs are listed in Table 3. Interestingly, there was a high negative correlation between self-reference and accomplishment, suggesting that the use of words in the accomplishment dictionary were not closely associated with the speaker's discussion of her own accomplishments. In addition, there was a significant positive correlation between ambivalence and self-reference, indicating that a higher level of language in the first person was associated with more hesitant and uncertain speech. To test the likelihood that the 13 women senators' mean rhetorical skills were representative of the overall political sample, we performed independent samples *t*-tests on all seven of the constructs, using the political norms as the test statistic. Due to the fact that multiple *t*-tests increase the likelihood of Type I error, we followed the Bonferroni correction procedure for multiple comparisons, resulting in an adjusted alpha of .007. This adjusted alpha level will be used throughout the article as the criterion for significance. The means, political norms, *t*-tests, and probabilities are located in Table 4. All of the test statistics were significant at $p < .001$, with the exception of the satisfaction dictionary ($p < .01$), which did not quite reach statistical significance using the adjusted alpha level.

Consistent with hypothesis 1, the women senators were much less aggressive than the political norm (mean difference = -6.13). In addition, the senators in our sample were much more ambivalent than politicians in the normative sample (mean difference = 5.93). Thus, hypothesis 1 is strongly supported, suggesting that women senators are in fact significantly less aggressive and more ambivalent than the sample of male politicians.

Hypothesis 2 stated that women senators would use more language focused on self-reference and accomplishment in order to overcome stereotypical questions regarding their competencies as leaders. This hypothesis was only partially

Table 3 Means, standard deviations, and intercorrelations

	Variables <i>n</i> = 124	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1	Aggression	3.76	3.09	—						
2	Ambivalence	18.79	7.64	.05	—					
3	Self-reference	13.89	7.58	-.02	.37**	—				
4	Accomplishment	10.81	4.97	.10	-.40**	-.32**	—			
5	Praise	5.82	3.05	.04	.12	.03	-.06	—		
6	Human interest	29.83	8.94	-.16	.08	.01	-.20*	.12	—	
7	Satisfaction	4.54	3.07	-.22*	-.25*	.09	.01	-.10	.01	—

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$.

Table 4 Comparison of women senators with overall and political norms

Variables	Aggression	Ambivalence	Self-reference	Accomplishment	Praise	Human interest	Satisfaction
<i>Overall norm</i>	5.43*** <i>t</i> = -5.81	12.85*** <i>t</i> = -6.13	7.55*** <i>t</i> = -6.13	14.37*** <i>t</i> = -6.13	6.18 <i>t</i> = -6.13	31.81* <i>t</i> = -6.13	3.28*** <i>t</i> = -6.13
<i>Political norm</i>	5.52*** <i>t</i> = -6.13	12.91*** <i>t</i> = 8.44	10.87*** <i>t</i> = 4.48	13.67*** <i>t</i> = -6.34	7.17*** <i>t</i> = -4.60	35.24*** <i>t</i> = -6.60	3.83** <i>t</i> = 2.76
Women senators	3.78	18.84	13.98	10.79	5.90	29.82	4.60
Barbara Mikulski	4.30	12.73	14.80	14.75	3.63	34.03	6.30
Dianne Feinstein	5.10	23.12	15.30	10.58	5.42	22.90	4.10
Barbara Boxer	5.00	23.38	20.00	6.32	6.20	32.80	2.90
Patty Murray	2.70	15.01	15.98	8.62	5.62	30.63	5.40
Kay Bailey Hutchison	2.60	22.58	12.70	6.68	6.66	37.20	3.60
Olympia Jean Snowe	2.00	17.42	10.71	11.50	4.03	27.86	3.71
Mary Landreiu	5.65	24.08	12.70	10.37	10.11	31.60	2.90
Susan Collins	4.20	15.20	5.80	12.08	4.94	19.70	5.00
Blanche Lincoln	2.25	17.26	20.87	12.41	5.19	32.50	6.62
Hilary Rodham Clinton	3.10	23.48	19.88	9.57	8.12	34.40	3.20
Deborah Stabenow	3.75	12.65	8.53	13.92	6.16	32.50	5.70
Maria E. Cantwell	2.35	22.51	13.80	10.30	4.82	21.70	5.00
Jean Carnahan	4.65	14.18	13.85	14.39	4.83	30.80	6.30

Note: d.f. = 123.
p* < .05; *p* < .01; ****p* < .001. Adjusted alpha level set to .007.

supported. While women senators did use significantly more language focused on themselves as speakers (mean difference = 3.11), they were significantly less likely to use language in the accomplishment dictionary than the political norm (mean difference = -2.88). These results suggest that women senators frequently use first-person references that direct the locus of action to themselves; however, they do not focus on task completion and ordered activities as frequently as the politicians in the comparative sample.

Finally, hypothesis 3 suggested that women might focus more on praise, human interest, and positive language in order to mitigate the potentially negative effects of challenging implicit leadership prototypes. Findings here were mixed, and mostly contrary to what we hypothesized. Women senators used significantly less language in the praise dictionary (mean difference = -1.27) and the human interest dictionary (mean difference = -5.43) than the political norm. In addition, the senators in our sample only used slightly more language in the satisfaction dictionary (mean difference = .77) than the politicians in the normative sample, and this difference did not reach significance. Thus, hypothesis 3 is rejected.

In order to examine whether or not more aggressive women senators compensated by using more people-oriented, positive language, we performed a median split to divide the senators into high and low levels of aggressive rhetoric. A one-way multivariate analysis of variance (MANOVA) was conducted in order to examine whether there were significant differences in usage of words in the praise, human interest, and satisfaction dictionaries based on level of aggressive language. The dependent variables included the three dictionaries, and the overall level of aggressive speech (high or low) was the independent factor. Overall, we found no significant differences between more and less aggressive senators on the dependent variables, Wilks' $\lambda = .98$, $F(3,117) = .67$, $p = .57$. Thus, we can reject the post-hoc hypothesis that senators who use higher levels of aggressive speech compensate by using higher levels of people-oriented, positive language as well.

We also reasoned that senators who have been in office for a longer period of time might use different rhetoric as they adjust to the leadership position and their minority status. We therefore divided the sample into higher tenure senators (elected 1994 or prior, $n = 6$) and lower tenure senators (elected after 1994, $n = 7$). A one-way multivariate analysis of covariance (MANCOVA) was conducted in order to examine whether there were significant differences on the seven rhetorical dictionaries based on the tenure of the senator, the independent factor. Because greater amounts of rhetoric were available for the higher tenure senators, the number of different words in the speech was included as a covariate to address this potential source of variance. Overall, we did find significant differences between senators with higher and lower levels of tenure on the dependent variables after controlling for the number of different words, Wilks' $\lambda = .88$, $F(7,115) = 2.35$, $p < .05$. Thus, we can reject the post-hoc hypothesis that the speech content of higher tenure senators is the same as that of lower tenure senators. However, the multivariate η^2 ; based on Wilks' λ of .13 indicates that the percentage of variation in the discriminant function explained by the senators' tenure is relatively low. Univariate analyses of covariance (ANCOVA) tests were conducted on each of the dependent variables as follow-up tests to the significant MANCOVA. Further examination of the non-adjusted means revealed that the higher tenure senators used significantly less language in the

accomplishment dictionary (higher tenure $M = 9.74$, lower tenure $M = 11.81$), and significantly less language reflecting praise (higher tenure $M = 5.18$, lower tenure $M = 6.41$). There were no other significant differences between higher and lower tenure senators, indicating that our overall pattern of findings cannot be simply explained by the amount of experience the senator has in her role.

Finally, due to the fact that our comparative sample predominantly consists of either presidential candidates or sitting presidents, we decided to examine the language of women senators in relation to the *overall norms* available in Diction as well. This additional step was taken to examine whether or not our findings might simply be attributed to the fact that senators engage in different types of rhetoric than politicians who have reached the presidential level. Thus, we examined our sample of women senators' language against a much broader sample that includes both political and non-political language. The overall normative data in Diction is based on the analysis of a diverse sample of 22,027 oral and written English-language texts that date from 1945 to 1998. Included in this normative data are corporate documents, political and social speeches, popular culture materials, news reports and editorials, everyday social interactions, face-to-face and mediated dialogues, and classic works of literature (see Hart, 2001).

The results from a comparison of the senators' language to the overall normative data are surprisingly similar. The 13 women senators were significantly less aggressive (mean difference = -1.65) and less likely to use terms in the accomplishment dictionary (mean difference = -3.58) when compared to the overall sample. In addition, they were significantly more ambivalent (mean difference = 5.99), and they used self-oriented speech much more frequently (mean difference = 6.43). Finally, the results from comparing senators' usage of words in the human interest, praise, and satisfaction dictionaries to the overall norms were also similar to the results from comparison to the political normative data. Women senators used slightly less language focused on human interest (mean difference = -2.00) and praise (mean difference = $-.28$), although these differences were non-significant. And again, the senators used more language in the satisfaction dictionary (mean difference = 1.32), and this difference reached significance using the overall norm for comparison.

Discussion

Overall, our results suggest that women face a difficult task as leaders in the high-powered role of US senator. Based on previous research from political campaigns and advertising, we hypothesized that women might downplay the use of stereotypically masculine leadership styles such as aggression in order to avoid the potentially negative ramifications of challenging implicit prototypes about women leaders. When we examined their rhetorical leadership over a 12-month period in their positions as senators, we found that women were in fact much less aggressive and more ambivalent than a comparative sample of male politicians. In addition, the senators in our sample were also much less aggressive and more ambivalent than an overall sample of oral and written texts produced in the US. Overall, these results reinforce stereotypes that women politicians are less aggressive and assertive than their male counterparts, and while we do not have data that bears directly on this

issue, is consistent with previous research that women bring a more collaborative and consensual style to the legislature.

We also hypothesized that women would engage in higher levels of rhetoric focused on their own competencies and strengths as a way of subtly challenging gender stereotypes about their leadership effectiveness. While women senators were more likely to use language focused on self-reference than both comparative samples, they were significantly less likely to focus on their accomplishments. This suggests that while women senators may be comfortable using language focused on themselves as the primary locus of action, they remain hesitant to explicitly emphasize their own accomplishments through the use of stronger and more direct language concerning their achievements, abilities, and ambitions. Again, this reinforces stereotypes and previous research that women are less likely to engage in self-promotion, emphasize their accomplishments, and take credit for their achievements (see Tannen, 1995).

One possible explanation for these findings may be that they are an artifact of more general gender differences in the use of language (Sillars et al., 1997). Women are socialized differently than men, and some previous research from linguistics and communication has asserted that there are consistent gender differences in communication styles. The different languages or 'genderlect' model developed by Robin Lakoff (1973, 1975) characterizes women's interactional style as uncertain, weak, and powerless through the use of such conversational devices as tag questions, qualifiers, and hedges. While the different languages approach has been criticized both conceptually and on the basis of inconsistent findings (see Crawford, 1995), research on gender differences and communication styles suggests that additional factors such as power, role, and identity may play a vital role in linguistic differences (Jones, 1999). Our results would seem to support this trend, as comparing our data with the overall normative sample from Diction suggests that the language of women senators may be even more stereotypically feminine than a wide variety of discourse from American society. Our findings indicate that as strong minorities in the US Senate, women senators may temper their language in order to avoid 'rocking the boat' and challenging existing gender stereotypes. As women in the Senate negotiate their relatively new identities in this high-powered role, our results may reflect less 'gender difference' and more 'the difference gender makes' (Cameron, 1992: 25).

Unfortunately, our findings cannot speak directly to *why* women's rhetorical leadership as senators differs from political and overall norms on aggression, ambivalence, and accomplishment. Eagly et al.'s (1992) study found that women in leadership positions were devalued when leadership was carried out in stereotypically masculine styles, and this devaluation was greater when leaders occupied male-dominated roles. It is unclear whether women senators are aware of these potential pitfalls and take measures to avoid them, or whether women senators have a different rhetorical leadership style from men altogether. Kathlene's (1994) research findings would seem to suggest that women approach the role of political leadership differently, and as a result, their language may reflect a completely different orientation to the leadership role (see also Fine, 1997). Further research is necessary to determine the extent to which women senators feel free to enact their leadership roles, without the constraints of both masculine and feminine gender stereotypes and expectations.

Our findings also suggest that women do not engage in more language focused on human interest and praise in order to endear themselves to their colleagues or to the American public. In fact, women actually used significantly less language in these dictionaries than the norms for presidential-level politicians. This may be an artifact of their relative newcomer status to the US Senate and a subsequent focus on negotiating the political landscape and the tasks immediately at hand. Alternately, this may be a result of efforts to avoid confirming feminine stereotypes of nurturance and people orientation in order to avoid being perceived as ‘mothers’ instead of ‘leaders’. Whatever the underlying reason, this may be an unfortunate challenge for women, as recent research in charismatic and transformational leadership has suggested that more references to collective identity and fewer references to individual self-interest are important components of this type of leadership (Shamir et al., 1994; see also Bligh et al., 2004a, 2004b). In addition, these authors theorize that more positive references to followers’ worth and efficacy, as well as the leader’s similarity to followers and identification with followers, are important elements of charismatic rhetoric. Perhaps even more relevant to women senators, these characteristics are increasingly important when the social distance between leader and follower is large (Shamir, 1995).

Taken together, this research suggests that women leaders should not abandon stereotypically feminine characteristics such as other-focus and nurturance as they move into top leadership positions. Unfortunately, in an attempt to challenge existing stereotypes that emphasize their nurturance and care for others, they may be failing to capitalize on an important competency that (some) women (some of the time) may bring to the legislative process. Overall, our results suggest that women bring a less aggressive and accomplishment focused style to their legislative roles, which might indirectly help to ‘rescue politics from the rampant individualism that results in deadlock or inadequate policy-making’ (Thomas, 1994: 13). However, we find little support for the assertion that their increasing numbers will transform the political arena along ‘kinder, gentler’ lines (p. 12).

Future research should also more directly tackle the issue of whether or not these different communication styles are associated with increased legislative effectiveness. There a number of ways to assess political leadership effectiveness, including: number and type of political activities, committee assignments, perceptions of constituents, perceptions of legislators, number of bills introduced and passed, changes in the political process, as well as media reactions and career progression. According to previous research, men and women legislators see the greatest impact of women legislators to be on legislation that focuses on women and women’s issues (Carroll, 2001). Rhode (2003) similarly points out that ‘without question, women in public office have made an enormous difference on issues of particular concern to women’ (p. 21). Thus, a variety of different variables are likely to be relevant when understanding in what ways and to what degree women’s rhetorical leadership will impact on processes, outcomes, and perceptions of their legislative effectiveness.

Obviously, the findings from this preliminary study should be interpreted with caution until further research can replicate the differences we found and begin to address the underlying reasons for the rhetorical differences in women senators as compared to previously established political and overall norms. Experimental

research designs benefit from the ability to control independent variables, and the current research is somewhat hindered by the fact that incumbency, party, and personality differences in the current senators could never realistically be systematically varied or controlled. It is also important to note that the current study utilizes a quantitative approach rooted in the assumptions of content analysis (see Krippendorff, 2004; Neuendorf, 2001), and as such follows the traditions of leadership psychology and political communication research. We acknowledge that this approach has many limitations, including that the linguistic constructs that we assessed would benefit from the addition of more interpretive, rhetorical, and qualitative analyses to shed further light on these issues. The addition of these latter approaches will allow us to examine the more contextually dependent features of discourse, and how stereotypes and prototypical behaviors may vary between male and female leaders.

Future research from a more traditional rhetorical approach (e.g. Trent & Friedenberg, 2004) or an organizational discourse approach (e.g. Ashcraft & Mumby, 2004; Fairhurst, 2007; Holmer-Nadeson, 1996; Holstein & Gubrium, 2000) would allow researchers to explore how women legislators position themselves within a 'space of action' (Daudi, 1986) that the intersection of multiple discourses makes available (see also Harré & van Lengenove, 1999). These complementary approaches are not subject to the limitations of the dictionary-based content analysis in the current research, and are likely more suited to seeing the ways in which women leaders may use language to creatively position themselves within both masculinity (Collinson & Hearn, 1996) and femininity (Ashcraft & Mumby, 2004) discourses.

For these reasons, the implications and conclusions from the current study must be viewed cautiously until these findings can be further explored and replicated. In particular, due to the fact that the majority of women senators are Democrats, the important role of party affiliation is difficult to control for, as is the role of geographic region, length of time in office, etc. As more and more women move into higher levels of political office, future research will have increasing opportunities to examine leadership rhetoric while more systematically controlling for these other factors.

It is also important to acknowledge that senators enact and portray themselves in ways other than discourse, and other aspects of their leadership behaviors may play a critical role in interpretations of their leadership effectiveness. The voting record of the senators, the committee assignments they seek and are assigned, where the senators publicly appear, who they are photographed with, and what is communicated on their websites all play critical roles in understanding the leadership of women senators. Thus, the current study of the senators' discourse is an incomplete look at how women senators both negotiate and manipulate the leadership landscape and influence perceptions of their leadership effectiveness.

Additional research in this area will also benefit from examining other women in high-powered and highly visible leadership positions. Further research into the unique role demands and gender expectations for women politicians will increase our understanding of the difficulties and challenges they face, helping to uncover and even minimize some of the barriers to women's advancement into higher political positions such as senator and president. In addition, research on women in the business and managerial realms will allow us to determine the extent to which women in business and women in politics face similar challenges and opportunities. Finally, incorporating women politicians at the state and local levels is an important

direction for future research in this area in order to understand how women's rhetorical leadership varies as they move up the political hierarchy.

Although the dictionaries included in the Diction program have been widely tested on texts in many different realms, we are unaware of any studies that have utilized this program to examine rhetorical leadership and gender. The current study thus represents only a first step toward developing and testing objective, quantifiable measures of the constructs that help us to reliably measure and clearly delineate women's rhetorical leadership and its ramifications for perceptions of their leadership and effectiveness. Our results suggest that women in the Senate face a complicated web of stereotypes, expectancies, and implicit prototypes of what it takes to be a woman and a leader in a highly powerful and very public role. In addition, our findings indicate that women's rhetorical leadership varies significantly from political and overall norms. It is up to future research to determine whether these differences represent true differences in leadership style, or whether they are the result of prevailing gender stereotypes and role expectancies that women remain hesitant to challenge.

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